

Man Singh and Geeta

"Our marriage is Atta Batta. It is more acceptable to the villagers now than it was 10 years ago," says Man Singh.

marriage is called 'direct'; the village folk speak of it as a blatant, desperate act that cannot be hidden. Birbal, 65, from the Panehari village in Hissar district, got married 'direct' 30 years ago. Around 140 such marriages have taken place in the village, he says. "Now it is *majboori* (necessity)," he adds, "Upper castes also do it now, even Jats."

But 'direct' is not the way for those on top of the social heap. For them, the 'triangle' form of Atta Batta is preferable. In a 'triangle', a man's wife's brother is married to his sister's husband's sister. Complicated as this is, it isn't easy to hide either as Ram Phal, 23, who married Saroj, 22, two months ago realised. The village knows about it, and he does not try to hide it, affirmatively saying, "It is not 'direct'." Within his extended family that lives on either side of the same muddy lane in Panehari, there have been many such marriages. Rajbeer and Suman, both 18, were recently married and are another 'triangle' couple.

Triangles have further morphed into intricate geometrical structures, conglomerates of families of relatives and friends, involving two or three villages. Intricate permutations and combinations are worked out to ensure all unmarried males in the conglomerate find wives. Secrecy remains high on priority: people outside the conglomerate must not know of this advanced version of Atta Batta.

Biju Nath, 50, (name changed), a Jat from Fatehabad district, specialises in carrying out these exchange marriages from a pool of 250 families in three districts. The pool is growing, thanks to his excellent networking skills. "I run it



like a cooperative and families are willing to pay me some money to make it appear a normal wedding," he says. But some families, usually 10, join hands on their own, ignoring gotra and other social restrictions. These groups have also found the best way to deal with the negative attributes of Atta Batta: they act like it didn't happen.

Neighbouring Punjab, facing the same problem, has been quick to take the cue. In Fatehgarh Sahib district, where the sex ratio is estimated to be below 800, Atta Batta has become very popular. Some villages in the region dominated by Jat Sikh farmers have only 600 girls per 1,000 males. So, desperate are they for an exchange marriage that a mentally-

challenged woman was married to a 35-year-old to facilitate the other half of the twin wedding. Atta Batta's growing success has taken it to the cities and even the relatively modern Punjabi community, as in Jind's Krishna Colony where 20-year-old Gita married Ashok, 28, from Panipat in return for Ashok's sister Bharti, 18, for Gita's brother, Jitender, 21.

That could change if the improving sex ratio continues to get healthier. The latest survey by the Haryana Government across 25 villages shows most now have more girls compared to boys in the age group 0-6 years. Shiv Bhatia, media adviser to Chief Minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda gives the credit to the Government's two-pronged approach: "The Government is following a carrot-and-stick-policy by giving incentives to those who have girl children and severely punishing those responsible for female foeticide." That, however, is unlikely to have an impact on the population of marriageable age for quite some time. Till then, Atta Batta, with all its incestuous implications, will continue to attract desperate householders. ■

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**Customs take a
back seat when it
comes to necessity.**
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SRINIVAS, whose village has seen
more than 100 such marriages